

TRAVEL

In Style

**SECRET SUMMER
HIDEAWAYS IN
SOUTHEAST ASIA**

**BEST ITEMS
TO WEAR
FOR PHOTOS**

Dining on
THE ROCK
KOH SAMUI

BALI
**YOU CAN'T
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Greetings

From Exotic Voyages

Another summer is coming, already! You might have been dreaming of a beach getaway after a long, cold winter, so, on page 18 we put together for you a fantastic list of the best summer getaways in Southeast Asia.

Our Marketing manager, James Thai, recently took a trip to Bali, the awarded TripAdvisor's best beach getaway last year, to see what all the fuss was about. What he found, however, was that Bali had so much more to offer than some nice beaches. Boasting exquisite food, a unique Hindu-Buddhist mix of beliefs and customs, and spectacular mountains, Bali should take a spot on everyone's "must-see" travel list. You can read more in our Expert's Story section on page 30 and see why James will certainly be back to this tropical paradise.

Flip through some first pages of this publication, you will find the latest Travel News that we have covered in the past few months.

In Cambodia, a rising star of the luxury hospitality industry, has just opened to international travelers. The Rosewood Phnom Penh Hotel, one of the newest members of the prestigious Rosewood brand, is a stunning piece of architecture, located right near the city center, and would surely be a fantastic choice for your stay in Phnom Penh. Turn to page 42 and discover how Rosewood applied their one-of-a-kind "A Sense of Place" philosophy in this brand-new Cambodian property.

If you enjoy fine dining experiences or are generally looking for a fantastic culinary experience, turn to page 48 to check out what the Dining on The Rocks restaurant in Koh Samui has to offer.

You may notice that this issue looks entirely different from the previous ones in terms of its structure. Having both renamed our core sections and added new ones, we hope this change is for the better. Do let us know if you like it. Inside this edition, the Travel Tips section on page 28 offers unique travel advice, like the most photogenic clothing to wear on your travels, while the Events section goes into more





depth about what we do to preserve the environments we love. We're raising awareness for bear killings in Vietnam, who are captured and killed for their "medicinal" bile-bears like Murphy, on page 52.

"Don't listen to what they say, go and see for yourself." Never has this old saying been truer than in the case of Southeast Asia. We can write as much as possible, and you can read all the articles in the world about this side of the globe, but nothing compares to what you'll see, hear, smell, and feel when you set foot in these exotic, new lands.

Dream big, and explore the options you have with us at Exotic Voyages. Talk to us today about the trip you dream of, and we can easily make those dreams a reality.

Exotic Voyages Team

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MALDIVES GOVERNMENT ANNOUNCES TRAVEL AND TOURISM ACTIVITIES WILL NOT BE AFFECTED BY THE COUNTRY'S CURRENT POLITICAL CLIMATE

Tourists thinking of cancelling a trip to the Maldives may want to head to the country's legendary beaches after all. While the government of the Maldives declared a state of emergency on February 5th, the Ministry of Tourism has said it is safe to travel. The Maldives' ambassador in London has stated that, "Flights, hotels, and other companies in the tourism sector will continue to operate as usual." Be sure to check for any last-minute updates before boarding your flight.





TWO BEAUTIFUL ISLANDS IN SOUTHEAST ASIA ARE GOING TO CLOSE

Thailand's Maya Bay on Ko Phi Phi island, as well as Boracay, in the Philippines, will be temporarily closed between June and September this year. So, you'll have to make other plans for your summer beach getaway if you were planning on visiting these beaches. Authorities anticipate that these closures will restore the delicate coral reefs have been damaged for years by tourists and local businesses. These measures will certainly help the areas stay as beautiful as they once were.





GLOBAL EXCHANGE OPENS ITS VERY FIRST OFFICE IN ASIA

Global Exchange is now operating out of the Hong Kong International Airport (HKIA), making currency exchange easier in Hong Kong than ever before. At the opening ceremony, company president Isidoro J. Alanis stated that the new office combines “the most innovative design with the highest quality standards of the world. The technological developments of our branches are aimed at offering a multilingual communication that facilitates attention to any international tourist.”



THE COMO UMA CANGGU, BALI OPENED IN FEBRUARY, 2018

Luxury aficionados rejoice: the COMO Uma Canggu in Bali, the latest accommodation from COMO Hotels and Resorts, opened in February. COMO's 14 resorts span the globe, and the COMO Uma Canggu is their third in Bali, firmly cementing their name in the Bali luxury resort industry. The new hotel consists of 119 rooms infused with a medley of Asian and Italian influences—surely a treat for the senses. Special features include the Beach Club restaurant, the Shambhala Retreat, specialized spa treatments, and pilates and yoga classes.





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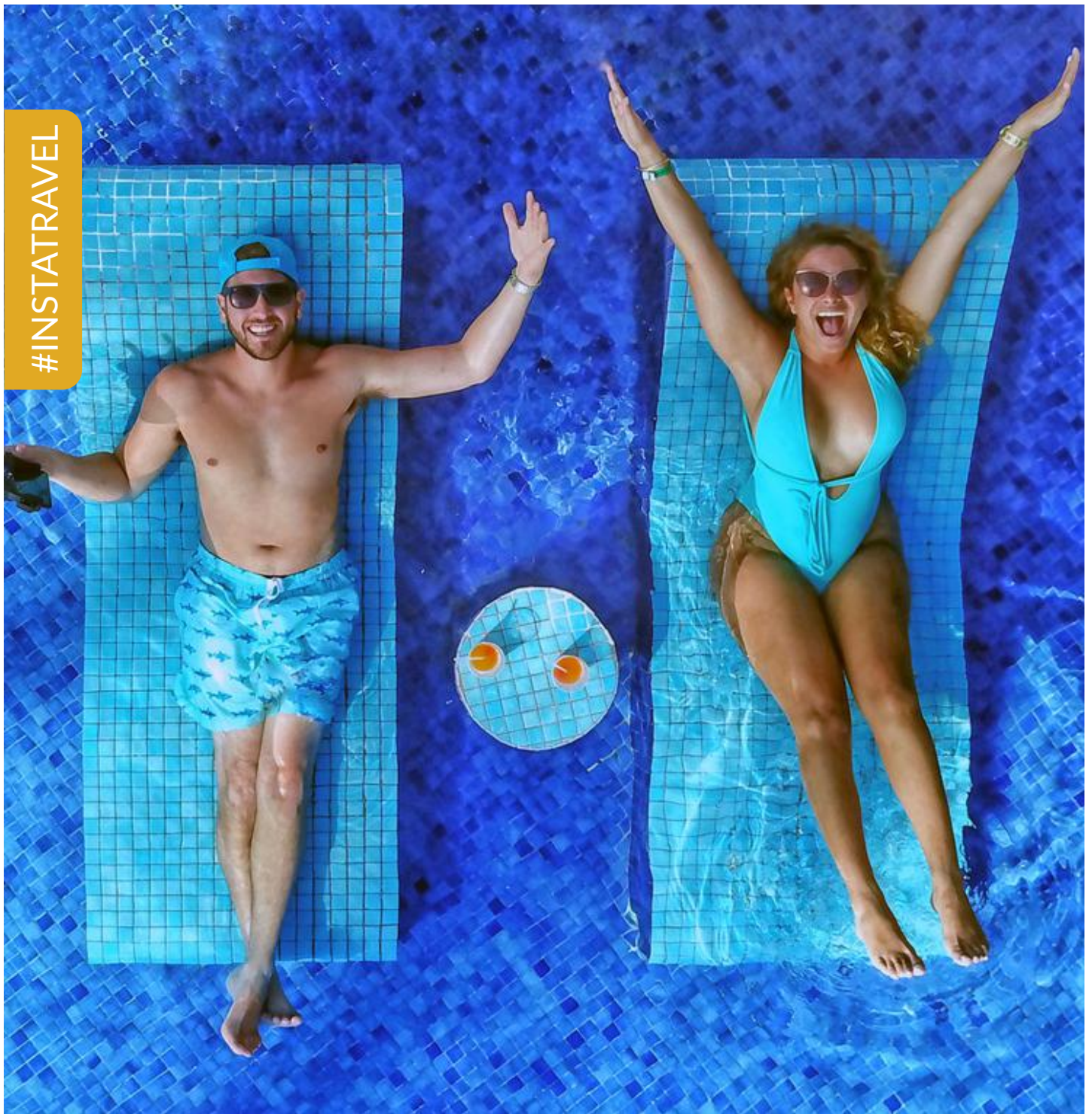
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TOUR

ASIAN QUALIFYING VENUE
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#INSTATRAVEL

Let pictures tell the tales of mesmerising journeys to Southeast Asia. Welcome to our #Instatravel pages, where the best photos taken by Exotic Voyages' clients will inspire you, sometimes move you to travel and explore the most amazing parts of the world.



Find us on Instagram
www.instagram.com/exotic_voyages

The sun was shining when I took this beautiful photo over the Wat Phra That Doi Suthep Temple. This is a grand, gilded place to visit in the city of Chiang Mai. Its main edifices and surrounding base create an interesting combination of colors that wowed me in a way that I never expected to be able to capture.

CHRISTOPHER CRUZ

Photographer, full-time blogger
thecanineexperience.com







Bali, after the rain, was emotionally beautiful. When the trees were still heavy and you could feel the fresh air through your eyes, everything around seemed quiet, peaceful to the mind, even to the soul.

RACHEL BURKE
From New York, US





We arrived just after a devastating typhoon, so Hoi An was perhaps not at its best. But the strength and determination of the people to restore the town after the typhoon was inspiring and by the end of the week, Hoi An looked splendid again.

SHAY FARRELLY, PHOTOGRAPHER

shayfarrelly.com



SECRET SUMMER HIDEAWAYS IN SOUTHEAST

From a little known Vietnamese bay, then a hidden Island nestled in Cambodia, and finally to a dreamy Thai town, here are 3 of the best-kept secrets for your 2018 summer in Southeast Asia



ASIA

d



1. SONG SAA ISLAND, CAMBODIA

18 miles off the coast of Sihanoukville, Cambodia is a secluded island, Song Saa. Unlike the UNESCO historic site Angkor Wat, which is packed with at least thousands of tourists each day during the high season, Song Saa is a private island: exclusive, luxurious, and indeed, not cheap, but worth every penny to enjoy the unparalleled beauty.

The fascinating story of Song Saa began in 2005, when Roy and Melita Hunter decided to stay in Cambodia for a year before moving to New York. On their first visit to Song Saa, and Song Saa's first encounter with foreigners, a local family simply asked if they want to buy their island at the price of \$15,000 USD.

Mr. and Mrs. Hunter came back a week later with a little bag full of money in exchange for the land rights. They started planning an exclusive gateway there, and the story of Song Saa's development began.

The pair has spent years and millions of dollars developing the Song Saa resort, cleaning the land and reefs, and creating a sustainable environment with the help of local people from surrounding islands. They bought old fishing boats off the locals, hauled them out of the water, and repurposed them as

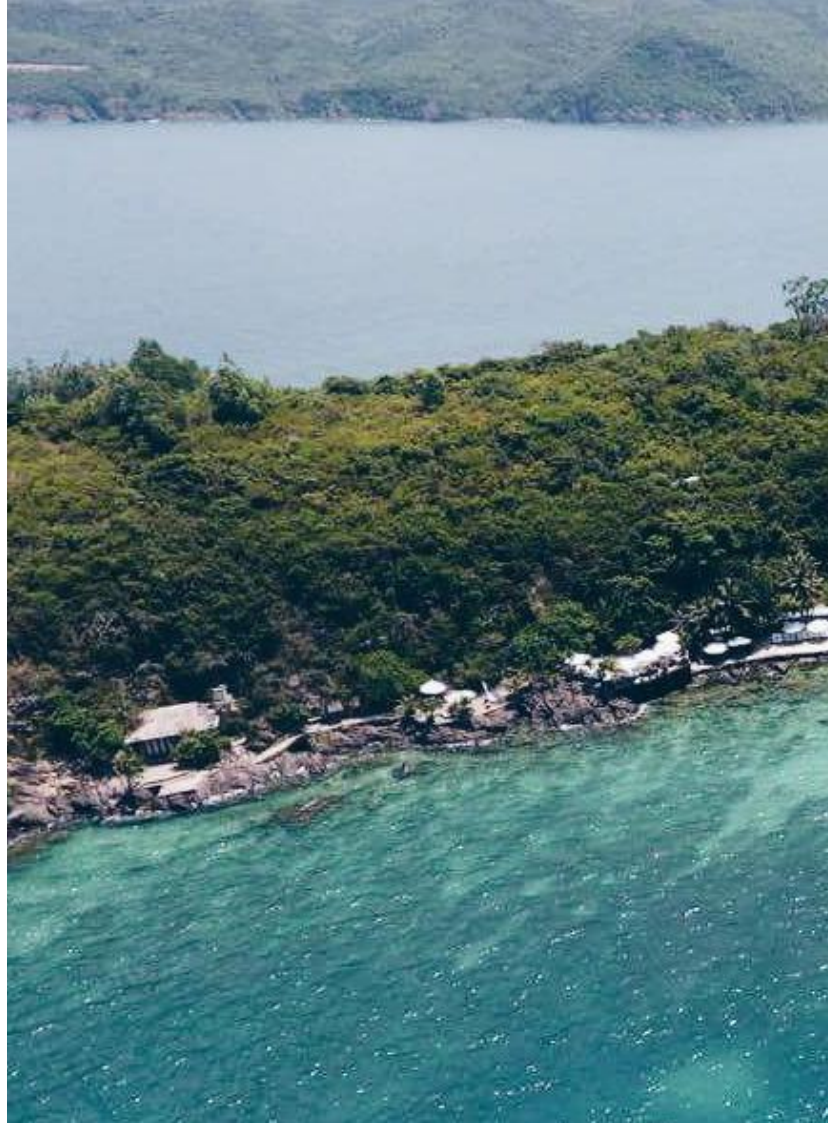




beautiful art as part of their cleanup efforts. Recycled materials, such as driftwood, wood from old boats, stone, and fallen trees lying on the banks of Song Saa and its neighbouring islands were incorporated into the construction of the resort.

Now, the property has 27 paradise villas spread across the twin-islands (Song Saa Private Island and Koh Song Saa) that sport pristine scenery, untouched beaches, golden sands, calm water, and tropical fish. All of them are built into the jungles or perched on stilts over the sea; certainly appealing to those with a real sense of both luxury and adventure, and who expect high standards of service and design. From Phnom Penh, you can take a 4-hour road trip to the Sihanoukville port, followed by a 30-minute private speedboat to the island.

You can also book a helicopter ride straight to the beaches from Siem Reap and Phnom Penh for a truly stunning experience. Prices for a stay on the island are around \$1,000 USD per night, which all goes towards exceeding your every expectation of an island resort. A watersports centre, where you can snorkel around coral reefs in the morning, kayak through lush mangroves in the afternoon, and, stroll along wooden walkways to a hilltop spa and champagne bar in the evening all contribute to the Hunters' vision of a one-of-a-kind island getaway experience.



2. NINH VAN BAY, VIETNAM

Ninh Van Bay is certainly not as popular as Halong bay or Phu Quoc, and far more enigmatic. Situated in the Hon Heo archipelago, 37 miles (60 km) north of Nha Trang city, Ninh Van Bay is fairly far off the beaten track for travellers. However, just a 20-minute boat ride from the Nha Trang's pier will get you to Ninh Van in the quickest and easiest way possible. But, if you want to take the scenic route, you can take a taxi or private car around Nha Phu Bay. Ninh Van, a sheltered bay, boasts extraordinary natural beauty, diverse wildlife, lush jungle forest, smooth white sand, and clear water still unspoiled by rampant tourism.





For many years, Ninh Van was an isolated area, surrounded by mountains and the ocean; practically inaccessible, except by boat. A road was first built in 2007, and only started to come into use around 2011. This road still remains only one of the few ways of accessing this secluded paradise, which gives the local village a chance to develop at a decent pace, while retaining its tranquility. Most of the area is covered in stunning beaches, tropical forests, garlic fields, and amazing snorkeling and diving sites.

However, Ninh Van Bay doesn't have many options for overnight accommodation, but the spectacular Six Senses Resort and An Lam Retreat do offer some truly amazing stays.

Not only do these resorts offer unparalleled privacy, but the two resorts' wellness & spa centers are also famous as perfect places for bodily and spiritual rejuvenation. Their traditional Vietnamese therapies will balance your mind and body, while top notch cuisine made with only the freshest organic products will please any inspired gourmand's palate.

3. PAI, THAILAND

Last, but certainly not least, is the dreamy town of Pai, Thailand, where nature, history, and culture unite in harmony. Those who know about Pai usually head there from Chiang Mai by a bus or private car, which takes 3 - 4 hours. Another option is taking a flight by Kan Airlines at Chiang Mai that gets you to Pai in only 25 minutes.

Throughout history, Pai was very cut off from outside world and fairly unconcerned with the Lanna empire until 1481 CE, when the Lanna Kingdom set down their law and authority in the area. Since then, Pai has, of course, kept up with the pace of development, but the small town mindset hasn't changed in hundreds of years. Nestled deep in the valley, Pai perfectly exemplifies natural beauty, from its endless mountains, incredible hiking trails, thermal springs, spectacular limestone caves, and beautiful waterfalls. But what really draws people to Pai is its tranquil atmosphere; sipping tea at sunrise without a soul in sight can be your perfect escape. Pai doesn't only boast tranquility, but a rich cultural history, as well, from the WWII Memorial Bridge, to the natural bamboo bridges over the rice fields, and playing with elephants in the rivers to immersing yourself in natural hot springs.

Pai is definitely not a party town for bar-hoppers and partiers. The town offers very little diversity when it comes to nightlife and entertainment, but you can indulge in the islands' penchant for elegant nostalgia. No place is better to do so than the Reverie Siam. This resort offers a cultural melange of Western style with the native Thai tradition,





conjuring up “daydreams of a bygone era, defined by romance and elegance. For the literati, you can immerse yourself in the silent world of words from a selection of the resort’s literary works. When darkness falls, things loosen up with live musical performances of jazz, classical, blues, folk, and ballads at the Silhouette Library. Enjoy the music and even dance to your heart’s content until you’re drawn back to your room for a peaceful, well-earned rest.



Planning a summer holiday to Southeast Asia, rife with paradise getaways, pristine beaches, and wild jungles? Contact our travel experts at inquiries@exoticvoyages.com to customize your trip today!



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1

Statement Jewelry

Even if you are a member of a camera-shy group; you still can achieve absolute picture-perfection with a chic statement necklace or fabulous statement earrings. With floral shapes and bright colors, the captivating adornment will provide a photogenic finish. Frame your structure with a perfect, and elegant touch to your look.

3

An Off-the-shoulder Top

An off-the-shoulder is a wardrobe essential that is flattering, flirty, and hides your pit stains. In case you have a large bust, go for a fitted navy or black one, and freely pose for superb photographs.

4

Wide Legged Pants

Simple, classic, and never goes out of fashion, a pair of wide legged pants is flattering on every body shape. Opt for a crop top and high-waisted trousers, this look will immediately show off your waistline and minimize great bulk.



5

A Fitted

There is no denying that a fitted blazer is a wardrobe essential. It frames your frame perfectly. Opt for a blazer with a sleeve that complements your imperfections.

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2

Maxi Dress

A Maxi Dress is an absolutely nice pick for a perfect photo as it does not hug you in all the wrong places. Instead, a loose and form-fitting maxi will elongate your body to create a favorable impression of a taller and slimmer figure!



T ITEMS WEAR FOR PHOTOS

It is officially time to pack away your high-necked sweaters and dust off summer clothes. Exotic Voyages unpacks must-have items to make your body curves stand out in photos.

Blazer

o item that can put your
in a good shape and make
e become lithe like a fitted
t for a suiting appearance
k blazer to be classy without
ons.



6

Strappy Nude Heels

If you are looking for an ultra-flattering type of shoes that can mix and match easily with all items and comfortable for hot weather? A light pair of nude heels is your friend even you have fat ankles! Your legs will gain more a few inches, and you are no longer need to ask for the help of an image editor app.





BALI

YOU CAN'T HELP BUT FALLING IN LOVE

Bali's diversity- the culture, sights, people, and especially the services- all made this island such a unique destination that should be on everyone's bucket list.

*James Thai
Exotic Voyages' travel expert,
on his recent trip to Bali with his family.*



Getting from Hanoi to Bali is not as easy as one might think, since we have to transit for 3 hours in Kuala Lumpur, but I have to say Vietnam Airlines has upped their game: my 3 year old son did have quite a bit of fun on board (for as long as he could).

When we got out of the departure gate, our operation manager was waiting together with our own driver and guide. Cold towels and some refreshments that made us immediately felt welcomed before we were off all the way to Ubud.

The hotels in Ubud were just lovely with a tranquil ambiance around that communes with nature since most of them were situated on hills and surrounded by endless green paddy fields. It is standard service here to have: morning power walks through the rice fields, afternoon tea and yoga lessons.

We decided to stay at the Alena Resort, a small boutique hotel located outside of Ubud, and they made some of the best welcome drinks I've ever tasted. With the ricefields and tropical jungles around, you can sense a calm and relaxing atmosphere. The room is really nice with beautiful decor and amenities like tile floor, solid wood, Alang-Alang thatched roof, and most importantly just a few

steps from the pool. The presence of the split gate created an experience of an ancient yet luxurious atmosphere and as a distinctive feature for a Balinese boutique villa. It was so romantic and blissful that my wife and I only wanted to immerse ourselves in the crystal clear pool, enjoyed each other's company, and got back to nature.





BALINESE FOOD

It would be a big loss if you miss the Ubud's downtown. This is a lively area with local shops, interesting restaurants and bars, you name it. We chose Cafe Wayan – one of the restaurants mentioned in *Eat, Pray, Love** for our dinner. Tranquil gardens, pavilions among lotus ponds that made us enjoy a relaxed and romantic atmosphere. We had the Balinese Smoked Duck followed by homemade baked breads that Westerners were very impressed when the chef came out to hand deliver a meal. In case you want to sample the variety of flavors, try their traditional Balinese Buffet offered every Sunday evenings.





TERRACES AND TEMPLES

The second day was all about rice terraces and temples. Needless to say, there is a large number of temples on this island, and importantly, each one was totally different from the next. The best way to learn about Balinese culture is by visiting its temples to get the hang of a rich mixture between Hindu and Buddhist customs. Balinese architecture is a centuries-old style of design that beautifully merges Bali's Hindu traditions and ancient Javanese elements. Their most recognizable features tend to be in harmony with the nature by using organic materials such as bamboo poles, thatched roofing, woven bamboo, coconut wood, teak wood, stone, and brick.





DANCE AND DRAMA

One of the experiences that I love the most is going up to Uluwatu Temple, one of six key temples believed to be Bali's spiritual pillars, perching atop a cliff. There you can watch the Kecak dance, depicting a love story from the Ramayana in which King Rama rescued Princess Sita. Uluwatu shared a splendid sunset backdrop overlooking the beautiful Indian Ocean that you cannot see anywhere else. The last light of the sun turns the blue skyline into brick red, and then a deep purple before it became totally dark except for the roaring fire in the middle of the iconic dance stage. That magical moment melted my heart.

The volcano visit in Bali is equally impressive, both watching it from far away and hiking to the top of the mountain. No matter what you choose, the sheer size and dramatic landscape will take your breath away. Having a picnic near one of Bali's sacred volcanoes while admiring its magnificent beauty is a signature experience that I would recommend to anyone.







THE BEACHES

No description of Bali is complete without an overview of their world-famous beaches. If you are a beach bum, then Nusa Dua is where you should be. With long stretches of white sandy beach and a lot of luxury hotels like St Regis or Ritz Carlton, it is the ultimate beach experience. If you prefer some water sports, then Tanjung Benoa is also a good place. I stayed at the Sakala Resort which has a really great beach club, with a large pool overlooking the ocean. They also have a huge pool running around the resort providing residents easy access.

Our stay was quite short and honestly, I could not have enough of this paradise! You would be missing out on so much thinking that Bali is only a beach destination because the diversity of this island. The culture, sights, people, and services are what have made Bali an exotic place that you should put on your travel bucket list!

Eat, Pray, Love: One Woman's Search for Everything Across Italy, India and Indonesia by Elizabeth Gilbert was published in 2006. The memoir chronicles her trip in three countries after her divorce and what she discovered during her travels.

Photos by: James Thai

ROSEWOOD

PHNOM PENH

A Journey of Senses



OD

enses

“Luxury hotel” is a term that everyone can define. From island resorts that are attractions in and of themselves to urban hotels that soak in and reflect the cities’ elegance, these accommodations offer visitors a lavish break from daily life, where your every need is cared for and your every expectation is not only met, but exceeded. But there are a few resorts that go beyond the superficial – opulent marble and stained glass – to give the their guests something more precious, intangible, and rarer than a pretty sight. Rosewood Phnom Penh is one of them.

Founded in 1979 in Dallas, Texas, Rosewood aimed to create residential-style luxury hotels that would provide guests with attentive, personalized services. Since the first hotel, ‘The Mansion on Turtle Creek,’ was transformed from the mansion of Sheppard King (the Texas cotton tycoon), Rosewood has developed and raised their reputation in many of the world’s most desirable destinations. And, with its booming tourism industry, Cambodia certainly cannot stand outside the list.

Rosewood Phnom Penh is not the only representative of the Rosewood Hotels & Resorts in Southeast Asia, with Rosewood Phuket and Rosewood Luang Prabang also drawing visitors, but it is the first urban hotel in the region. Now that it has finally been completed, affluent visitors

to Cambodia, the “Kingdom of Wonder,” can have access to the top 14 floors of the stunning 39-storey Vattanac Capital Tower and stay in ultimate luxury. If the accommodation itself isn’t tempting enough, all of the city’s main attractions, including The Royal Palace, the National Museum, Wat Phnom, and the Art Deco Central Market are just a stone’s throw away. So, if it’s your first time to Phnom Penh and you’re eager to take in the vibe of the city, Rosewood would be at the very top of your accommodation list.

As you approach the Rosewood Phnom Penh, you can start to feel the embrace of opulence and tranquil privacy. You can look out your top-floor window at 188 meters (615 feet), and gradually feel truly decompressed as you take in the sight of the city skyline, as well as the stunning view of the Tonle Sap and Mekong Rivers; a journey of senses has begun.

The mastermind designer of this stunning piece of architecture is Melbourne’s BAR Studio, which earned their fame through many masterpieces like the Rosewood Beijing, the Grand Hyatt Seoul, the Park Hyatt Sydney, the Grand Hyatt Hong Kong, and the Park Hyatt Shanghai. BAR Studio found their inspiration for the Rosewood Phnom Penh from Cambodia’s culture, history, and traditions to



create a subtle, “classic-meets-contemporary” style. In just a single, sloping structure, the rich history of Khmer Empire’s architecture and the heritage of the French colonialists, the sensibility of the destination, and the vibrancy of ancient Cambodian art comes together gracefully.

175 suites and guestrooms of Rosewood Phnom Penh are among the largest in the city, ranging from 50-square-meters to 225-square-meters. Their designs feature spacious, residential-style living spaces with airy living rooms, graceful bedroom, chic foyers, private bars, and remarkable views of the legendary rivers or the city skyline through floor-to-ceiling windows. Each of the rooms is an undeniably elegant accommodation, no matter where it faces.

Phnom Penh, the culinary heartland of Cambodia, serves up cuisine ranging from the hearty to the rarefied in its many bars and restaurants. But in the Rosewood, you needn’t travel outside their doors to sample the finest Asian, Japanese, and even European dishes. Dining options include the warm *Brasserie Louis*, which serves the delicacies of French comfort foods and regional Cambodian favorites while presenting a panoramic vista of the city through its floor-to-ceiling windows. *Cut* – a bar and grill and *Iza* – a Japanese izakaya-style restaurant that invites guests to sample course after course and socialize over a lively meal– are also right at your fingertips. However, the highlight of the Rosewood’s dining options is the stylish whiskey bar *Sora* – translated as “sky” from Japanese – the most effortlessly stylish bar in Phnom Penh. Perched on a



lovely terrace on level 37 above Monivong Boulevard, it boasts unobstructed views of the Cambodian capital and a massive selection of the finest single malt whiskeys around the world.

Those looking for sumptuous relaxation can take advantage of the *Sense, A Rosewood Spa* level 33. This private spa features seven treatment rooms, all-well designed to put you at ease as soon as you set foot in them. The spa’s therapists, trained in traditional Khmer healing herbal medicine and ancient techniques, will revitalize your body and rejuvenate your spirit. You can also plunge into the 20-meter (65 foot) indoor pool for a morning swim, or make use of the fitness centre’s state-of-the-art equipment, available 24 hours a day. For families with kids, the Rosewood also provides a special



service with fun activities, tailor-made cuisine, and amenities crafted just for our younger guests' enjoyment.

But, as every savvy traveler knows, lavish rooms, bars, spas, and other amenities are standard for 5-star hotels. They make your life more comfortable, but they can't replace personal service. The Rosewood stands out among other luxury hotels by providing the highest quality personalized services to each and every one of its guests, and they can do so by focusing on building an incredible team and staff. Their principle is simple: the Rosewood looks not only for experience, but a personality and attitude that puts every client at the forefront of their minds. The Rosewood aims for absolute customer satisfaction, and this can only be achieved through impeccable attention to the service they provide.

The tourism industry is developing rapidly in Cambodia; the number of travelers coming into the country is increasing every year, and the new \$1.5-billion Phnom Penh airport is going to make it even easier for people to visit. The Rosewood hotel doubtlessly has something new and exciting to contribute to Cambodia's touristic development. While there is an endless list of must-sees and experiences in Phnom Penh and Cambodia, there is also the luxurious brand, Rosewood, for those who want simply to relax and enjoy the ultimate opulence during their stay in Cambodia.



Dining on **THE ROCK** *KOH A*





CK SAMUI

After spending all day exploring Koh Samui, we reached the northernmost point on the island in time for a pre-ordered dinner at *Dining on the Rocks*. It first caught my eye when I was searching for a fine dining establishment in Koh Samui on the internet. The picture of its glorious, sweeping panoramas out to the Gulf of Thailand blew my mind so easily that we decided to book a table here 2 weeks in advance. Under the dazzling light of the end of the day, I have to admit the restaurant became even more gorgeous than I expected – it certainly didn't disappoint. Only wooden chairs, tables and cozy yellow lights serve as the minimalist decorations, and it works perfectly. The most outstanding aspect is the open-sided dining area with a large terrace built right on the rocks; it's as if you're dining right over the sea.

When we approached the main gate, a cheerful, local Thai waiter welcomed us. He was kind enough to recommend us a table which would give us the best view of the sea. The scene was almost poetic: the table, gently lit and warmed by aromatic candles and adorned with sweet-scented local flowers, gave us a view out towards the rocky, sea-sprayed cliff. If the setting wasn't overwhelming enough, the dining options were even more impressive; there are 6 prix fixe and nearly 30 dishes à la carte. Unable to decide, we finally followed our waiter's suggestion: a culinary journey called "*Expressions*".

The gorgeous dining experience began with a unique kind of salad, chicken and egg, and a duo of tuna: *tartar and seared*. Each portion is just enough to satisfy, and the flavors expertly complimented one another. The salad was a mixture of vegetables, roasted nuts, and Samui homemade goat's cheese mousse, which was not only distinctive but truly elegant in taste and presentation. The egg yolk confit and tuna tartare were soft and unbelievably fresh, owing to their mostly locally-sourced produce.

Next came three most exquisite main courses we have ever had. The *duck breast*, complimented wonderfully with celeriac cous-cous, green peas purée and pickled fennel, was a real delight for our taste buds. The beef cheek was braised perfectly to preserve the soft texture, soft enough to melt in my mouth. The *Catch of the Day*, toothfish, laid on a luscious white bean purée and was topped with a savory chorizo marmalade. Local farmers breed the fish on the nearby beach and provide the



restaurant with a dish is as fresh as paired this meal w 2015, which round

Finally, our excellent *mango yogurt roll*, made extra savory and bananas are p tropicality, and the enjoyment. Moder used were doubtle of the original flav *Mediterranean Esse* almonds and cand elegant end to suc



new catch every day, so that every humanly possible. Of course, we with a glass of Terrazas de Los Andes ed our three courses off perfectly.

ent meal was wrapped up with a sweetened by slices of banana and with a sprinkle of nuts. Mangoes ractically Thai symbols of refreshing ey were expertly crafted for our n culinary techniques that the chef ssly effective in exploiting the purity vors. My partner opted for nce, traditional biscuit with roasted ied orange for dessert. What an h a luxurious dinner!

Depending on the number of courses you like, the price per person ranges from THB 2,800 for a 3-course set to THB 3,800 for a 5-course set. There are also some menus arranged by the chef with beautiful names, for example “Expressions” at THB 4,000. Wines are ordered separately with various options from 3 glasses to 5 glasses at the expense of THB 1,800 to THB 2,500 each person.

*Dining on the Rocks is a wonderful experience, from sight to taste. It is a holistic journey across the world of the most authentic cuisine in an exceptionally beautiful location at the very northern tip of Koh Samui. Contact our Thailand travel expert **Summer** (havy@exoticvoyages.com) to arrange this dining experience for your luxury trip.*

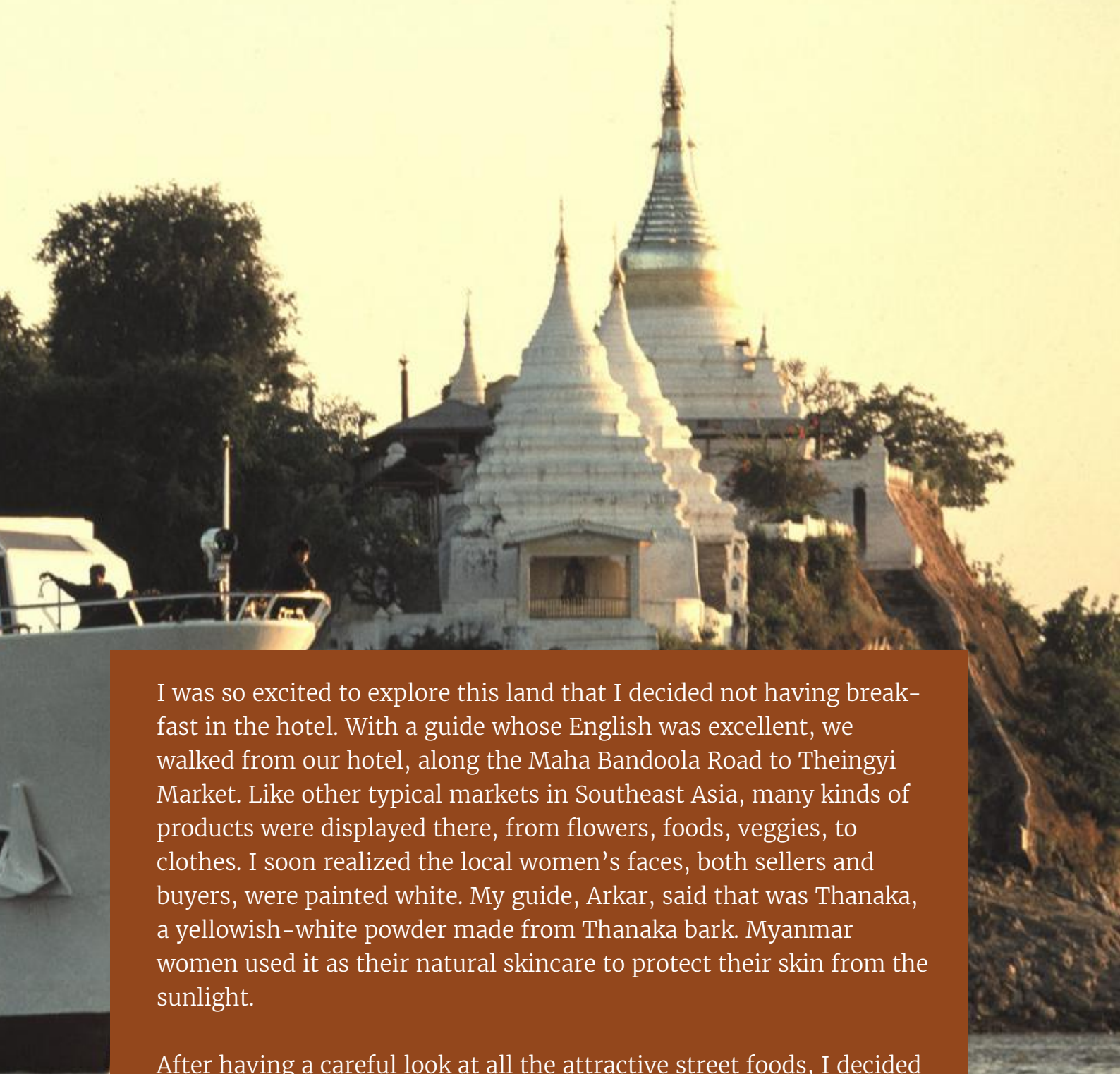


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THE MYSTIC IRRAWADDY

There I was, in the heart of Myanmar, Yangon on a trip of Exotic Voyages to discover this mysterious country. And Yangon was just the beginning.



I was so excited to explore this land that I decided not having breakfast in the hotel. With a guide whose English was excellent, we walked from our hotel, along the Maha Bandoola Road to Theingyi Market. Like other typical markets in Southeast Asia, many kinds of products were displayed there, from flowers, foods, veggies, to clothes. I soon realized the local women's faces, both sellers and buyers, were painted white. My guide, Arkar, said that was Thanaka, a yellowish-white powder made from Thanaka bark. Myanmar women used it as their natural skincare to protect their skin from the sunlight.

After having a careful look at all the attractive street foods, I decided to try my luck with Mont Lin Ma Yar (which meant 'husband and wife snacks'). Rice flour batter was added to a large hot iron pan which had many small, round holes that resembled a muffin tin. My Mont Lin Ma Yar was topped with quail eggs and chopped spring onions. The two halves then were joined, like a husband and wife, to make one round crunched cake. I also bought a takeaway sugarcane juice from an old man. He attached small bells to the wheel which was used to squeeze the stalks to juice. You don't need to see the vendors, but you are still aware they are very close if you hear the tinkling.



Arkar suddenly asked me “Do you want to know about your future?”. I looked at him curiously “Could I?”, he said “Yes”. With a mystic smile, he took me to Sule Pagoda Road, showed me a middle-aged man sitting on a concrete bench. He didn't look any different than the other Burmese Men I met on the streets, except he was holding my future in his mind. He took my right hand (if you are a man, it would be your left hand), and turned my palm to the light. He pressed it in many points, stretched my fingers, and used his index finger to run over the wrinkles. “You are kind and friendly. You are emotional. You will have three kids, two girls and one boy”, “You cannot save money, you always spend of it”, he continued in poor English. “You eat too much, but you have a good health”. And if that was not enough to impress me, he predicted: “You will hurt your leg in a motorcycle accident”.

Immediately, my mind came up with a thought of our upcoming 12-day journey. I turned to Arkar and asked him with a little worry: “Shall I be on a motorbike?” Arkar smiled, “No, we will cruise from Bagan to Mandalay, on a boat.”

Arkar explained the itinerary to me. We would take a boat trip along the Irrawaddy River – the legendary river of Myanmar going through many significant sites of the country. It was not a normal voyage that you could get anywhere and anytime. There were few travellers interested in the river, but there were great rewards for inquisitive people like us. I could not say how interesting it was to watch the local

life from a boat. This was where you discovered the deeply spiritual way of Burmese life. I watched with delight as fishermen cast their nets at dusk and graceful white oxen waded into the water. I saw the large rafts made of bamboo logs with huts where people stayed for around two weeks while floating downriver to the markets. And along the banks, the farmers were working in the peanut fields, their wives were washing the family's clothes on the banks, and their children were playing happily. Life and tranquil scenes were passing by peacefully.





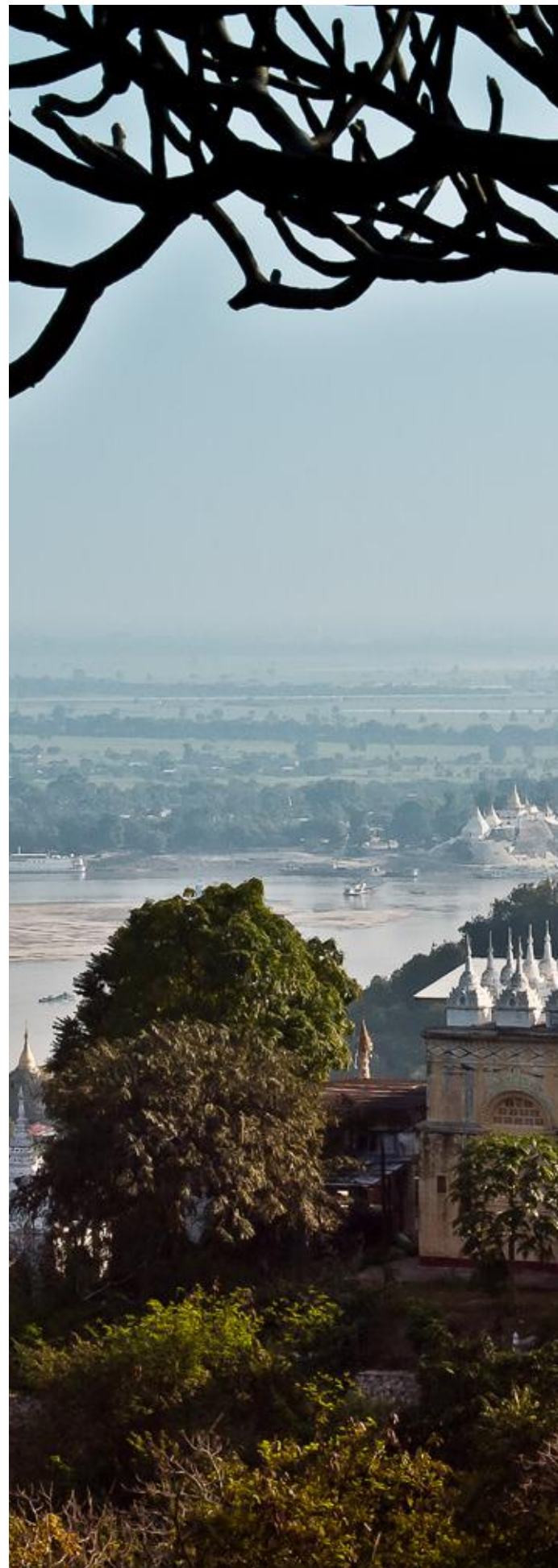
After decades of being off-limits, Burma opened in front of us a whole new world with thousands of temples and several former royal capitals, which were kept secret for millenia.



The timeless Irrawaddy River took us through many ancient craft villages and impressive cultural treasures between Bagan and Mandalay. Every day during the journey, I was gently woken up by the sound of chanting from waterside monasteries (Could you imagine of any wake-up call more mysterious than that?) Grab a book, I started each new day by reading, something I could hardly do if I was in the city, and continued our legendary voyage on the longest river in Myanmar.

The boat usually stopped to visit the local villages along the Irrawaddy River. I had the chance to walk through thousands of temples of Bagan dating back from the 9th century, and then to Hpo Win Daung and Shwe Ba Daung cave complexes, which contained nearly a thousand small caves and hundreds of Buddha statues and, by a horse-cart ride through the sleepy Ava (Inwa) to admire the glorious 200-year old Bagaya Kyaung Monastery. We crossed the photogenic U-Bein Bridge built from a thousand teak logs, and made our way through 600 ivory colored pagodas, monasteries, and meditation shrines of Sagaing Hill – the spiritual hub of Myanmar. Walking on bare-feet in the temples, I could not help but admire the wonderful frescoes, ancient architectures, and giant Buddha statues. It was easy to meet groups of young monks studying or spot cheeky monkeys keen on asking you donate food to them.

In the villages, we met some of the most friendly people in the world. It was Shwe Pyi Thar, a typical Burmese village, which was known for its palm candy (a traditional sugar found in most homes in Burma). To make the sugar, they cut into the palm tree, and hung an





earthen pot under the cut to harvest the sap. I looked admirably at a man in a yellow t-shirt, climbing up a towering tree with a pot hanging around his waist. He would climb more than 30 trees twice a day to collect his pots. The fresh juice would be boiled on a large pan over an open wood fire until it thickened, then they poured it to a cloth, waited until it dried, and formed it into small pieces by hand. These candies then went on to be traded and brought income back to people in the region.



However, the village on our boat trip which impressed me most was Yandabo. The locals in Yandabo made incredible terracotta pots for a living. They still used their ancient manual method to produce traditional pots. Watching skillful women shape the clay on a spinning wheel by hand to form different shapes of pots was delightful. If you wanted, you could try to do it yourself. It's more difficult than it looks. Even though you are very careful, expect a distorted product that you hardly believe in your eyes. The two villages, Shwe Pyi Thar and Yandabo make different products but they have one thing in common: the hospitality, especially from the children we met at the villages' schools. The facilities were basic, but the children were incredibly well-behaved. They welcomed us warmly by singing to us their favorite songs. This country was rife with poverty, yet kids were always playing and laughing. Their smiles were such the biggest gift we received on our journey.

I came to Burma with an enthusiasm to absorb the ancient culture that I could not find elsewhere in the world and I learned so much more. I left with an understanding of this mysterious land and a happy heart. The local children have taught me that, no matter your circumstance is, keep smiling to bring happiness to you and people around you. Because most smiles are started by another.

You may ask me "What about the motorbike accident?" Well, it was completely forgotten.

Aisha Dao - travel writer

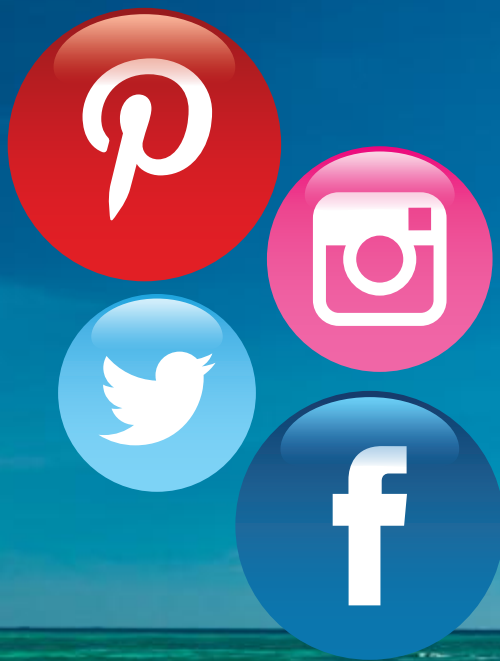
Our 'Journey of Distinction' are indigenous voyages we recommend travel readers to take in time of the up-coming season. If you enjoy reading this journey, want to have experience like hers, contact our Myanmar travel expert, Mai Phuong (maiphuong@exoticvoyages.com) to get help planning your trip.





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